

What AI Does Best

The class title points at three ideas: patterns, probability, prediction. You’ve met them in almost every lesson. Now we get to use them.

AI will take on almost anything you ask: writing, planning, summarizing, coding, drawing, whatever you throw at it. But being willing to try and being good at it are two different things, and AI is far better at some kinds of work than others. It’s at its best at four of them, and each one traces back to a mechanism you already learned. Naming them turns ‘AI can do X’ into ‘AI does X well because Y.’

We saw this firsthand building this course. AI coded every page and every interaction you’ll see, and for that it earned an **A+++**. It also wrote the first drafts of the text, and there it was a **C-**: points in the wrong order, explanations that missed what we meant, no real feel for how a lesson should flow. Same tool, same project, opposite results, because the two jobs play to completely different strengths.

WHAT AI EXCELS AT

AI is built to do four things really well.



Pattern matching

Patterns in, patterns out.

Code is patterns. So is reformatting data, or turning an outline into prose. AI trained on millions of examples and learned each pattern. Hand it any input and it predicts the pattern that fits.

GOOD FOR

- Coding
- Reformatting messy data
- Pulling fields out of documents
- Turning an outline into prose



Vast exposure

Seen a thousand of these before.

Training gave AI more material than any human will read in a lifetime. So for most everyday questions, it has seen many versions of yours, and many examples of how good answers get shaped. But exposure gives patterns, not proof.

GOOD FOR

- Brainstorming angles
- First drafts of common documents
- Explaining at any level
- “How do people usually handle...” questions



Compression of meaning

Finds the signal in long stuff.

It boils long text down to its core meaning, then pulls the relevant parts back out. Long documents get split into chunks, each one condensed into a summary it can search. Pull specific answers out of long material in seconds.

GOOD FOR

- Summarizing
- Extracting key points
- Finding the relevant section in a long document
- Translation



Probabilistic generation

Ten versions in ten seconds.

It builds each answer one small piece at a time, each piece a best guess chosen from many options. A variation setting controls how much it wanders. Same prompt, different output every time.

GOOD FOR

- “Give me 10 variations”
- Rewriting in a different tone
- Alternative phrasings
- Creative options

Eight real tasks. For each one, pick the strength doing the heavy lifting. Some are close calls.



Four engines. A thousand uses. Almost everything AI is good at is one of those four strengths pointed at the right task. The skill isn’t memorizing a hundred clever prompts. It’s spotting which strength a job needs, noticing when none of them fit, and knowing when one fits but you still shouldn’t reach for it. That last call comes up again in How Much to Check: sometimes the right amount of checking is to leave the tool closed.

TRY IT

AI is strong at some kinds of work and shaky at others. Match each task to the strength it plays to.